are ‘Machiavelli’s “lions”’ who ‘advocated heroic war for just ends, win or die’.[7]

Murty divides ancient Indian idealists into two schools as well: the Buddhists and the Jain–Hindu pacifists. The former ‘thought the entire world could be converted to dharma [cosmic order] by peaceful means’, while the latter ‘advocated ahimsa or non-violence but did not rule out the use of force’.[8] Thus, India’s ancient diplomatic tradition was a mix of isolationism and involvement, not very different from non-alignment in modern times. For that reason, Nehru often described non-alignment as ‘a positive concept with an implicit philosophy behind it’ and insisted that ‘its roots go back to the time of Asoka and earlier’.[9]

American political scientist Quincy Wright thought that Indian philosophers provided a better framework for understanding international relations than Western ones. Unlike the West, which has been influenced by the Platonic insistence on universality, ancient Indian philosophy and political thought did not assume a universality of ideas. Hence, it is not surprising that Indian governments ‘have seldom been consistent in the application of whatever principles they may profess’. [10] Echoing Quincy Wright’s views, Giri Deshingkar points out, ‘One prominent characteristic of the Hindu reading of reality is that the good is always mixed with or accompanied by the evil.’ [11]

This ties into Nalini Kant Jha’s assertion that ancient Indian philosophers did not equate ‘public with private morality’ and understood that ‘a statesman acting on behalf of the state has to take into account the interests and wishes of his people while deciding on his action’. [12] Nehru frankly admitted this in his speeches over the years, and some of his actions, such as the police action in Goa, reflected this view. Unlike his approach to the French Indian colonies of Pondicherry, Karikal, Yanam, Mahe and Chandernagore, now called Chandannagar, where he waited for the colonial